Two Straight Years Past 2,000

Student copy (project or hand out)

The following lays out what the 2026 measles case totals show about where the disease is spreading, and why public health officials measure each community against a single vaccination threshold.

1 The United States has recorded 2,030 confirmed measles cases in 2026 as of June 4, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. The prior year, 2025, ended with 2,288. With the 2026 total already past 2,000, this is the second straight year the country has crossed that mark.

2 The cases are not scattered evenly. The CDC reports that 93 percent of them, 1,890 of the 2,030, are outbreak-associated, meaning they trace to a known cluster rather than to a lone traveler who infects no one else. That leaves about 140 cases not linked to any cluster. Even so, the reach is broad: 40 jurisdictions have logged at least one case this year, plus Washington, D.C.

3 One outbreak accounts for much of the recent total. Centered in Spartanburg County, South Carolina, it ran from October 2, 2025, until the state declared it over on April 26, 2026, and reached 997 confirmed cases. State health officials describe it as the largest measles outbreak in the country in more than 35 years.

4 The South Carolina record points to one variable above the others. Of the cases counted there as of March 3, some 95 percent, 945 of 990, were in people who were unvaccinated or whose vaccination status was unknown. The measles, mumps, and rubella shot, given in two doses, is the standard protection; where it is absent, the virus moves through a population with little to stop it.

5 Epidemiologists watch a specific number for measles. Public health guidance holds that roughly 95 percent of a community must be immune to keep the virus from circulating freely, a level often called community immunity. Below that line, a single case can seed a chain. The CDC reports that kindergarten vaccination coverage for the measles shot has slipped under that 95 percent mark, the threshold considered necessary for community protection.

6 What the 2026 count shows, then, is less a sudden event than a math problem holding steady. The cases concentrate where coverage has thinned, and the national figure has stayed above 2,000 for a second year while that coverage sits below the level considered necessary to stop the virus from spreading. Whether 2027 looks different depends on numbers that are being recorded now, school district by school district.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The relationship between the second paragraph and the fifth paragraph is best described as one in which the writer first

A) establishes the national case total, then disputes whether that total can be trusted

B) maps where the cases occur, then identifies the immunity condition that explains that distribution

C) presents competing explanations for the cases, then selects the most likely one

D) describes one state's outbreak in detail, then generalizes it to the whole country

2. In the final paragraph, the phrase "a math problem holding steady" primarily serves to

A) question whether the reported case counts can be trusted

B) assign blame to public health agencies for the rising totals

C) frame the outbreaks as a predictable consequence of measurable conditions rather than a sudden crisis

D) predict that case numbers will rise sharply in the coming year

Discussion questions:

1. The writer orders the piece to arrive at the community-immunity threshold only in the fifth paragraph, after the case totals and the South Carolina outbreak. How does saving that figure for late in the piece shape the way a reader understands the numbers that came before it?

2. Every figure in the opener is attributed to a named body, and the writer avoids emotive language about the outbreaks. What does that restraint gain for a reader's trust, and what might it leave out for a reader trying to feel the stakes of the data?

Writing prompt (Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay that analyzes the rhetorical choices the writer makes to convey a stance toward the 2026 measles data. In your response, consider how the writer's ordering of evidence, consistent attribution to named bodies, and restraint in diction work together to position the case totals as the product of measurable conditions rather than a sudden crisis.